

ATLS 4519 • FIRST CLASS

Learn, Vibe, Build.

Becoming a builder in a world where ideas can become artifacts faster than ever.



OUR STARTING QUESTION

What does it mean to be a **builder** now?

Not just someone who writes code. Someone who can turn intention into something another person can encounter.

QUICK PULSE

Who is in the room?



**I have built
something with
code.**



**I feel like a
complete
novice.**



**AI helped me
become a
builder.**

THE PROMISE

**Building is
becoming more
accessible.**

Access is not the same as
judgment. This class is where we
practice both.

**Imagine.
Articulate.
Revise.**

THE COURSE BENEATH THE COURSE

This looks like a computer class.

It is really a class about cognition, communication, and
creativity.

Think before you outsource thinking.

Develop an intention. Notice assumptions. Break a problem apart. Decide what “better” actually means.



Make your thinking available to others.

Articulate a vision. Ask useful questions. Challenge an answer. Give and receive feedback. Show your work.



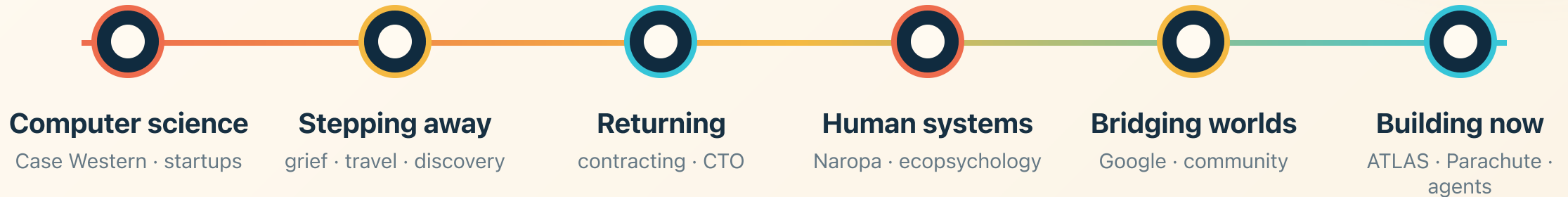
Bring something into form that did not exist before.

Follow curiosity. Work across media. Make surprising connections. Use AI to expand expression—not replace the impulse behind it.



WHY I AM TEACHING THIS

One path through technology— and away from it.



The point is not to follow this path. It is to notice that technical work belongs inside a life.

YOUR TURN

2:00

**Tell us enough to begin knowing
you.**

- Name + what you are studying
- Something you want to learn
- Your experience with AI
- Something you want to make possible

Listen instead of rehearsing. Your turn will come.

10-MINUTE BREAK

**Stretch. Talk to someone whose
path surprised you.**

HOW THE CLASS WORKS

A weekly practice—not a capability checklist.



SEE

Watch a real workflow

MAKE

Create an artifact

SHOW

Let others encounter it

TRACE

Name process + failure

NEXT

Choose the next edge

THE WEEKLY UNIT

One artifact. One human trace. One share.

01

Artifact

Make something another person can encounter—even if it is small or unfinished.

02

Human trace

Write at least one paragraph in your own words: what you did, what changed, what you learned.

03

Share

Demo the work, give a short talk, or teach us what happened in the process.

Thoughtful engagement matters more than polish.

WHAT COUNTS AS A DEMO?

Show the workflow—not only the victory.

01

Intent

What were you actually trying to make happen?

02

Stuck point

Where did the process misunderstand, break, or surprise you?

03

Judgment

What did you change, reject, or decide—and why?

A TINY FIRST PRACTICE

Human signal → shared meaning → AI draft → human judgment

Write · 3 min

One thing you want to make, change, or understand—and why it matters to you.



Ask · 4 min

A partner asks questions until the intention becomes more specific.



Judge · 8 min

We give a few signals to AI, critique its synthesis, and revise it together.

THE OPERATING PRINCIPLE

AI proposes.
Humans remain responsible.

For the intention. For the judgment. For the effect on other
people.

TOOLS

Flexible tools. A common floor.

Use what serves the work.

ChatGPT + Codex, Claude, Gemini, Grok, local models, creative tools, paper, cameras, physical materials.

We will learn in public.

Codex is available through CU and will be our common starting point—not the only legitimate path.

GRADING

A visible structure for an exploratory class.

60%

Weekly studio cycle

Artifact + human trace +
prepared share.

20%

Studio presence

Attendance, listening,
participation, and useful
feedback.

20%

Final project

A culminating artifact,
showcase, and reflection.

Feedback points forward. Grades report completion and participation—not artistic polish.

ATTENDANCE + COMMUNICATION

Two no-fault passes. Then use the recovery path.

Two passes

No documentation and no explanation required.

Life happens

Communicate before class or as soon as you reasonably can.

Stay connected

Complete a make-up share or contribution so the studio does not lose your voice.

Do not come sick. Formal accommodations and religious observances do not consume passes.

Three paragraphs. No separate artifact—yet.

1. Where am I starting—from AI experience to what I already know how to make?

2. What do I want to become capable of, and why does it matter to me?

3. What might I make—and what obstacles or support can I already see?

AI may ask you questions. The submitted prose should be yours.

WE WILL DESIGN THIS TOGETHER

Your learning edges will shape what I teach next.

You bring intentions, artifacts, questions, failures, feedback

I bring workflows, guests, structure, challenges, support

We build a studio where the room gets more capable together

FOR NEXT WEEK

**Bring one honest intention.
Leave ready to make.**

You do not need to know exactly what you are doing yet.

LEARN, VIBE, BUILD

Make something. Show your work.

Then decide what the next version needs.

